LEARN · GRAMMAR

A2

Present Simple vs Continuous



Present simple describes **routines and facts**; present continuous describes what's happening **right now** or around this period of time.

ROUTINE VS RIGHT NOW — AND THE VERBS THAT BREAK THE RULE

ROUTINE / FACT	HAPPENING NOW
present simple	**present continuous**
She goes to the gym on Mondays.	*Look! She's swimming.*
Water boils at 100°C.	*I'm studying French this year.*

BUT: thought / feeling / sense verbs are never continuous

want · know · like · understand · believe · own

— even when it's true right now

✗ I am understanding it now.

✓ I understand it now.

1 Use present simple for…

Routines and habits, facts and general truths, schedules and timetables. Frequency adverbs (always, usually, often, never) go before the main verb.

- I **get up** at 7am every day.
- Water **boils** at 100°C.
- The train **leaves** at 6pm.
- I **always check** my email in the morning.

2 Use present continuous for…

Something happening right now, a temporary situation around now, a fixed future arrangement, or a changing situation.

- She's **reading** a book (at this moment).
- I'm **studying** French this year.
- We're **meeting** him on Friday.
- The climate **is getting** warmer.

3 Watch out for

Stative verbs (thoughts, feelings, senses) aren't usually continuous: I **want**, I **know**, I **like**, I **understand**, I **believe**, I **own** (not 'I am wanting').

4 Common mistakes

✗ She work every day.	✓ **She works every day.**	-s for he/she/it
✗ I am understanding it now.	✓ **I understand it now.**	'understand' is stative
✗ Look! She swims.	✓ **Look! She's swimming.**	happening right now = continuous
✗ He go to work by bus.	✓ **He goes to work by bus.**	-es after a consonant + o

APPLY · PRACTICE

A2

Simple vs Continuous Practice

A Choose the correct word

1. Look! She ___ her hair. **(does / is doing / do)**
2. Water ___ at 100°C. **(boils / is boiling / boil)**
3. Be quiet! The baby ___. **(sleeps / is sleeping / sleep)**
4. He ___ French, Spanish and English. **(speaks / is speaking / speaking)**
5. I ___ that this plan will work. **(believe / am believing / believes)**
6. He ___ his teeth twice a day. **(brushes / is brushing / brush)**

B Complete with the verb in brackets

1. She usually ___ (walk) to school, but today she ___ (drive).
2. The children ___ (play) in the garden at the moment.
3. He ___ (not / usually / work) on Sundays, but this Sunday he ___ (work).
4. I ___ (not / understand) this question!
5. This bag ___ (belong) to my sister.
6. Look, the baby ___ (cry) because she's hungry.

C Find and fix the mistake

1. I am always drink coffee in the morning.

   _____

2. He is knowing the answer.

   _____

3. Look! It is rain outside.

   _____

4. Every weekend she is playing tennis with her sister.

   _____

5. He usually catch the 8 o'clock train to work.

   _____

6. They building a new shopping centre downtown at the moment.

   _____

D Write it two ways: a habit, then right now

1. she / read / a book

   EVERY DAY _____ RIGHT NOW _____

2. he / play / football

   EVERY DAY _____ RIGHT NOW _____

3. she / walk / to school

   EVERY DAY _____ RIGHT NOW _____

4. he / teach / maths at the local school

   EVERY DAY _____ RIGHT NOW _____

E Speak

say it out loud with a partner

1. Make a sentence: 'I always..., but today I am...'
2. Ask your partner 'What do you usually do on weekends?' and 'What are you doing this weekend?'